

“Hasina and Friends”

A Case Study of ICT4D Project Failure in Bangladesh

Introduction

ICT for Development (ICT4D) involves utilizing Information and Communication Technology to enhance social, economic, and political progress, particularly in underdeveloped nations. The initiative harnesses resources like computers, mobile devices, the internet, and digital platforms to elevate living standards and empower communities. ICT4D gives individuals access to essential information regarding health, education, agriculture, and market trends, which aids them in making educated choices and tackling difficulties. It also promotes remote education, telehealth services, e-governance, and digital finance, thereby improving the accessibility and efficiency of crucial services. By addressing the digital divide, ICT4D promotes social inclusion, empowers disadvantaged groups, and fosters engagement in development activities. Additionally, it promotes economic growth by supporting entrepreneurship, creating jobs, and expanding access to broader markets.

In summary, ICT4D leverages technology to promote human advancement, social empowerment, and sustainable development. In Bangladesh, ICT for Development plays a vital role in enhancing education, healthcare, and governance. Efforts such as digital classrooms, e-health services, and e-government platforms increase access to essential services, empower local communities, and contribute to economic growth. ICT4D helps to close the digital gap, promoting social inclusion and fostering sustainable development throughout the nation. For my project, I chose the “Hasina and Friends” website. “Hasina and Friends” is the first interactive online learning platform launched by the government of Bangladesh, designed for children aged 6 to 16. It features games and stories that help them explore the country’s history, culture, environment, health, and digital literacy. But sadly, this innovative project stopped after 2 years. This project had a budget of 180 million TK. This is what makes this incredible project a failure within days.

This analysis aims to investigate the “Hasina and Friends” ICT project to uncover the reasons for its failure. The study intends to identify the technical, organizational, and social obstacles that impeded its success, as well as to derive insights for future ICT4D initiatives in Bangladesh. The focus will be on the project’s design, execution, stakeholder participation, and overall social impact. Additionally, it will take into account external elements such as funding, policy backing, and community involvement. Any projects unrelated to “Hasina and Friends” or the wider ICT4D landscape in Bangladesh will not be included in this examination.

Project Overview

The “Hasina and Friends” project was an ICT initiative initiated by the ICT Division of the Government of Bangladesh as part of the larger Innovation Design and Entrepreneurship Academy (IDEA) project. This

web-based interactive platform aimed to educate children and young people through engaging digital stories and games.

The project received significant government funding, with about BDT 18–20 crore specifically allocated for the website component from the overall IDEA budget of BDT 443 crore. However, detailed information regarding the total funding and duration of the project is not widely available in public records. The “Hasina and Friends” portal was officially launched on September 28, 2022, coinciding with Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina’s birthday, and was intended to function as a lasting digital educational resource thereafter. The goals of the “Hasina and Friends” platform were to create an engaging and interactive learning space for children aged 6 to 16, focusing on topics such as the environment, health, education, culture, national values, and digital connectivity through stories and games.

The site featured 32 interactive stories and 12 games designed for various age groups, aiming to both entertain and educate users on important themes. It aimed to foster creativity, patriotism, and responsible citizenship among the youth of Bangladesh in a digital context. The main audience for the project was children and teenagers aged 6 to 16, divided into three age groups (6–9, 9–12, and 12–16), with the content tailored to meet age-specific learning goals. The initiative sought to engage young learners throughout Bangladesh, providing a localized digital platform available in both Bengali and English to enhance accessibility. The platform utilized a web portal, interactive gaming applications, and digital storytelling techniques to engage its users.

While specific details regarding the backend infrastructure or software frameworks were not publicly disclosed, the project integrated web development and game design to produce an educational technology resource designed for internet-connected devices.

The project’s alignment with national digital objectives can be understood within the framework of Bangladesh’s Digital Bangladesh Vision 2021. This initiative emphasizes the use of ICT to enhance education, expand digital accessibility, and foster the development of a knowledge-based society. “Hasina and Friends” was positioned within this broader strategy by offering an innovative digital learning tool aimed at cultivating digital literacy and knowledge among the youth, in line with the government’s goal of integrating ICT into education and youth involvement.

Implementation Process

The implementation of the Hasina and Friends platform commenced with its planning and tendering phase under the Innovation Design and Entrepreneurship Academy (IDEA) project by the ICT Division of Bangladesh. Initial steps included project conceptualization, setting objectives, and budget allocation, with an estimated allocation of BDT 18–20 crore for development. In March 2021, the ICT Division issued a tender for the creation of 12 gaming applications as part of the project, followed by another tender in July 2021 for the web portal, indicating a multi-phase procurement method to engage developers and vendors.

Once the tenders were awarded, the design and development phase began, with contracted IT firms working on the interactive stories, educational games, and web interface tailored for children aged 6 to 16. The

platform was developed in both Bengali and English, featuring 32 stories and 12 games intended to educate users on topics such as the environment, health, education, and digital connectivity.

The launch concluded with a prominent inauguration on September 28, 2022, coinciding with Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina's birthday. This ceremony was attended by government officials and stakeholders, marking the completion of the platform's development.

Regarding management structures, the ICT Division was responsible for coordination, with designated project directors and government officials overseeing supervision and reporting. Budget allocations were made for software development, content production, and promotional activities. However, the management and coordination strategies faced criticism due to post-implementation audits revealing cost irregularities and questioning the effectiveness of the planning and monitoring processes. By early 2025, the platform was taken offline, indicating issues with sustainability and operational management.

In summary, while the project adhered to standard stages from planning and tendering to development and launch, the absence of sustained operational support and oversight diminished its long-term viability.

Analysis of Failure

The Hasina and Friends project is often viewed as an unsuccessful ICT4D initiative due to major flaws in its planning, execution, governance, and long-term viability. A critical issue was the inadequate planning and suboptimal project design. While the platform intended to deliver digital learning resources for children, there is scant evidence of conducting a thorough needs assessment or pilot testing prior to its widespread launch. Reports suggest that around BDT 18–20 crore was allocated for the development of the web portal and games, an amount significantly higher than the typical market rates for comparable educational platforms.

This indicates a lack of effective cost-benefit analysis and poor resource management, which are frequently cited as reasons for the failure of large-scale government ICT projects (Prothom Alo, 2024). In addition to issues related to financial inefficiency, the project faced significant technical and infrastructural challenges. Although Bangladesh has made strides in digital accessibility, consistent internet connectivity and device availability for children, particularly in rural regions, remain inconsistent.

The project depended primarily on a web-based platform that lacked sufficient offline or low-bandwidth options, which limited its outreach to the very demographic it aimed to assist. Furthermore, just two years after its launch, the platform became inaccessible, highlighting inadequate technical support and the lack of a sustainable operational strategy (Prothom Alo, 2023). Capacity deficiencies and inadequate management frameworks further weakened the initiative. After the project's implementation, investigations indicated that officials in charge had insufficient knowledge regarding budget details and technical deliverables, highlighting a limited institutional capacity to manage complex ICT systems effectively. This deficiency in skilled monitoring and evaluation diminished accountability, allowing inefficiencies to remain unaddressed.

Additionally, political and administrative factors influenced the project. The branding, launch timing, and symbolic context of the initiative suggest that political visibility may have been prioritized over its

educational effectiveness. This politicization shifted attention away from essential aspects like pedagogical quality, user engagement, and long-term impact, a trend noted in various state-led ICT4D projects (Prothom Alo, 2024). Ultimately, the project faltered due to insufficient stakeholder involvement and a lack of long-term sustainability planning.

Key participants such as teachers, parents, education specialists, and children were not adequately engaged in the design of the content or in providing feedback. As the initial funding and government interest waned, there was no system in place for updating content, fostering community ownership, or integrating the platform within the education system. As a result, the platform quickly became irrelevant and lost the support it needed to operate. In summary, the failure of “Hasina and Friends” underscores the risks associated with ICT4D initiatives when there isn’t a balance between technological aspirations and thoughtful planning, institutional capacity, accountability, and sustainable design.

Impacts and Consequences

The abrupt cessation of the Hasina and Friends project had notable social, institutional, and policy implications. For the intended audience, particularly young learners, the termination meant the loss of a potentially enriching digital educational tool.

Many children became aware of the platform through promotional activities and launch events, but its unexpected unavailability led to confusion and diminished trust in digital learning initiatives. This adversely impacted attempts to foster consistent digital engagement among children, especially at a time when ICT-driven education was being increasingly prioritized across the country. The failure of the project at the institutional level significantly damaged the credibility of the ICT Division and other involved organizations. Public reports pointing to overspending, inadequate oversight, and a lack of transparency raised substantial concerns about governance and accountability in government-led ICT4D efforts. Consequently, trust among policymakers, development practitioners, and the general public in large-scale ICT investments diminished.

This skepticism could deter future funding approvals or collaboration from stakeholders for similar digital education initiatives. The project led to several unintended negative outcomes, such as reinforcing the perception that some ICT initiatives prioritize political visibility over genuine developmental impact, fostering public skepticism towards state-sponsored digital programs. Significant financial and human resources were wasted on a project that failed to produce lasting results, representing a lost opportunity to support more affordable, community-driven digital learning initiatives. Ultimately, this failure demonstrates how poorly planned ICT4D projects can damage public trust and slow progress toward inclusive digital development.

Lessons Learned and Proposed Recommendations

The failure of the Hasina and Friends project offers several crucial insights for the design and implementation of ICT4D initiatives in Bangladesh. One significant takeaway is that technology-focused projects cannot thrive without a solid development rationale. Despite its digital aspirations, the project suffered from a lack of adequate needs assessment and genuine stakeholder involvement, leading to poor relevance and minimal

long-term effects (Prothom Alo, 2023). This highlights a prevalent issue in ICT4D, where initiatives are often created in a top-down fashion, overlooking users' contexts and daily realities (Heeks, 2002).

Another important lesson relates to financial planning and accountability. Reports of overspending without corresponding results suggest inadequate cost-benefit analysis and ineffective monitoring, which ultimately eroded public confidence (Prothom Alo, 2024). The project also reveals gaps in institutional capacity. Limited technical expertise among officials hindered effective vendor oversight and compromised quality control. Research indicates that weak institutional capacity can lead to project failures, even with adequate funding and political backing (Heeks, 2017).

Additionally, the lack of a sustainability strategy, such as ongoing funding, content updates, or maintenance, illustrates how many government ICT initiatives falter once initial political or administrative interest wanes (Prothom Alo, 2023). Based on these insights, several actionable recommendations can be made.

Firstly, future ICT projects should adopt a user-centered design approach, engaging children, teachers, parents, and education experts from the outset to enhance relevance and usability. Secondly, strong monitoring and evaluation frameworks must be established to audit and measure performance for transparency and efficiency. Thirdly, capacity building within government agencies is crucial; project managers should receive training in ICT project management and impact assessment. Lastly, sustainability should be integrated into project design through long-term operational planning, dedicated maintenance budgets, and alignment with existing education systems. Implementing these strategies can help Bangladesh avoid repeating past ICT4D failures and ensure that future initiatives lead to inclusive and sustainable development.

Conclusion

The evaluation of the Hasina and Friends initiative highlights how even well-intentioned ICT projects can falter when technological ambitions lack robust planning, governance, and sustainability measures. While the project aimed to enhance digital learning for children and was in line with national digital development objectives, it was plagued by poor planning, inflated expenses, limited engagement from stakeholders, and insufficient institutional capacity. Additionally, technical shortcomings, the absence of long-term maintenance plans, and a lack of user-focused design further diminished its effectiveness, leading to its premature termination.

Consequently, despite considerable public funding, the project failed to achieve significant or lasting developmental impacts. This case provides valuable insights into the challenges of digital development in Bangladesh. It reveals that top-down, politically motivated ICT projects often focus more on visibility than on actual impact, which diminishes public trust and wastes resources. The failure of "Hasina and Friends" emphasizes the importance of participatory planning, accountability, and capacity building in ICT4D efforts. Ultimately, it highlights the need for digital development in Bangladesh to prioritize inclusive, transparent, and sustainable solutions that truly meet user needs and address development goals.

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